

SCORE BOARD The Linux Choice

Distribution Name	Best Linux 2000	Corel Linux 2nd Ed	Mandrake Linux 8.0	Red Hat Linux 7.1	Storm Linux	SuSE Linux 7.2	Turbo Linux 6.1
Features							
GUI Installation	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	No
Kernel	2.2.16	2.2.6	2.4.3	2.4	2.2.13	2.4.4	2.2.16
XFree86	3.3.6, 4.0.1	3.3.5	4.0.3	4.0.3	3.3.6	4	3.3.6
Display card detection	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Monitor detection	Yes	Yes	1024x768 problems	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Contact	G.T. Enterprises	G.T. Enterprises	G.T. Enterprises	G.T. Enterprises	G.T. Enterprises	G.T. Enterprises	G.T. Enterprises
Price	Rs 700	Rs 1,800	Rs 400	Rs 7,600	Rs 1,800	Rs 3,000	Rs 1,995
Phone	080-6606093	080-6606093	080-6606093	080-6606093	080-6606093	080-6606093	080-6606093
Fax	080-6671407	080-6671407	080-6671407	080-6671407	080-6671407	080-6671407	080-6671407
E-mail	gtcdrom@vsnl.com	gtcdrom@vsnl.com	gtcdrom@vsnl.com	gtcdrom@vsnl.com	gtcdrom@vsnl.com	gtcdrom@vsnl.com	gtcdrom@vsnl.com
Web site	www.bestlinux.net	www.corellinux.com	www.linux-mandrake.com	www.redhat.com	www.stormlinux.com	www.suse.com	www.turbolinux.com
Grade	B	B+	B+	B+	B-	A-	B

SuSE Linux 7.2 costs Rs 3,000, which is pretty good considering the customisation and work put into compiling such an operating system. There are seven CDs and a DVD for those who have a DVD drive. SuSE Linux also has a huge application database that includes music and sound creating tools. It also includes anti-virus and backup software, as also VMWare for users who need to run Windows and Linux at the same time.

Star Office 5.2 and KOffice are included with the whole distribution and there are Internet tools such as messengers, firewall's proxies, etc. It also includes the Crypto File system for security users. Buying SuSE Linux is certainly a good deal. It

has everything you would need. There is also IP video telephony and installers for SuSE Linux over a network. There are demos of games and some other applications too.

Corel Linux, which is a good distribution for home users, comes packed with three CDs, which include the installation CD, source CD and a Loki games CD. There is also a detailed manual. The package costs Rs 1,800, which seems a bit costly given what's included in the package. A better choice would be to pay a little more and get a package such as SuSE Linux 7.2, which gives you a lot more.

CONCLUSION

We received all kinds of distributions aimed at the desktop user. All of these distributions are improvements over the earlier versions in terms of interface and features. When it comes to hardware detection, features, the bundled applications and the ease of use, **SuSE Linux 7.2** comes out as a clear winner. And at Rs 3,000, the price tag isn't too high either.

When you install a desktop Linux distribution, you're basically looking to replace Windows, or run both in conjunction. However unlike Linux, Microsoft products cost much more and come with no extra applications such as office suites, image editing tools, online tools, small services, etc.

You need to either download freeware applications from the Internet, or buy commercial applications off the shelf to compensate for what's not there, and is needed. Besides, the package includes more than just the installation itself. SuSE Linux gives you the operating system itself and a whole lot of programs such as office suites, and media editing and viewing tools.

RedHat is also comparable on this count as it comes with 11 CDs. Compared to SuSE, RedHat does not require too much customisation, but it does include a lot of software and packages in the default install.

Mandrake Linux is more compact than the other distributions. The applications included are largely the basic default applications installed with KDE and Gnome. Other versions of Mandrake with manuals, etc, are available, but these cost a bit more. Corel is good for home users who have never used Linux but are keen to try a distribution that has a

straightforward installation process. Features and software that are installed with the distribution are, however, very basic. The components of the distribution are very old and outdated as compared to the other top distributions. 



SuSE: offers a large number of usable packages

Substitutes for Your Favourite Windows Apps

Microsoft Office	: StarOffice
Winamp	: X11Amp, Xmms
ICQ	: LICQ
mIRC	: Xchat
Internet Explorer	: Netscape Navigator, Mozilla
Microsoft Outlook	: Netscape Messenger
Microsoft Frontpage	: Netscape Composer
Realplayer for Windows	: Realplayer for Linux
Network Neighborhood	: Lin Neighborhood
Yahoo Messenger for Windows	: Yahoo Messenger for Linux